TEN

Canaries

NELL · DAY 23,249 · TUESDAY 9 JUNE 2026

MY FIRST WEATHER report went up on the Monday: the young ones in the jobs most exposed to the new systems, who aren't being sacked, only not being hired, in a study careful enough to end its title with a question mark. I called it "The canaries". I thought of an ironed vest on a hook. I got more replies than I'd had for the letter, and one of them was four lines long and had no greeting.

Your recording. 1:01 to 1:20. Run it through a spectrogram, you'll get a grid, twelve by twelve. I've been closing that grid as a fault since 2019. I can show you if you can be on the ring road at 1:30. Don't bring a phone.

So at twenty-five past one on Wednesday morning, I was standing behind a bin store in a borrowed hi-vis, with my phone on my kitchen table, eleven miles away, looking at the least interesting building in England.

No windows. No name, only a small sign, *Coldharbour Data*, and a number. A long pale box with a fence round it and a hum you felt in your fillings. A fire door at the back opened four inches, and someone said, "You're on my left. Come round."

Teo Brandt was about thirty-five, small and tidy, with ear defenders round his neck and his head tilted a little to one side. He was deaf in the left ear. Ten years of server halls, or something before that; he'd stopped asking. He looked at me for exactly as long as it took to check I had no phone, and he looked at his watch.

"Sheila does her round on the hour and it takes her eleven minutes," he said. "She's lovely. She will absolutely call it in. I've got you till two, and you are a contractor from Fans, if it comes up. It won't come up. Don't touch anything. Don't stand under the domes, they're on a three-week overwrite and nobody ever looks unless they've got a reason." He held up the door. "Don't be the reason."

I'd spent six weeks being written down by a keycard. I knew exactly what I was doing, and I stepped over the sill.

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COLD, FIRST. THEN the noise, which wasn't a noise after the first minute, only a pressure, a thing you leaned on. Long aisles of black cabinets ran away under white light, every one behind a mesh door, every door full of small green stars. It smelled of nothing. I'd never been anywhere that smelled of so entirely nothing.

Teo walked fast, on the balls of his feet. He didn't whisper; nobody could have heard a whisper. He leaned in on my good side and talked in short bursts, like a man reading out a parts list.

"I'm not a conspiracy person. I want that clear. I'm a ticket person." We turned left. "Alarm goes, I open a ticket, I look, I close the ticket. Twenty nineteen, I get a fault on a power feed that draws a picture on my monitor for about a second. Squares. I log it. *No fault found.* It comes back a month later. *No fault found.* Two thousand, one hundred and six tickets, as of tonight. Same picture. Nobody has ever once rung me up about it."

"Why me?"

"You had the only other copy." He looked at me sideways. "And you said what you were scared of. Most people on the inter-

net just say what they're angry about."

He stopped at a cage. It was the size of a tennis court and hung with its own lights, softer than ours, bluish, expensive. A polished sign on the mesh said *Lanternwork*, and through it I could see machines stacked to the ceiling, flickering so hard they seemed to shiver. All over the world people were arguing about what was going on in rooms like this. Somebody had put a pot plant in there.

"That's the customer. Everyone knows that. That's where the money is," Teo said. "They'd burn this building down for another rack. That's the point of what I'm going to show you. Mind the tile."

The next cage had no sign.

It was much smaller. Eight cabinets in a row, with a plain padlock and a tag on it with a reference number. There were no blue lights, and no little stars, either. The doors were solid and grey. Teo took a tablet from under his arm and held it low, against his stomach, so the dome at the end of the aisle couldn't see.

"Rented since before I got here. Billed as idle. Stored equipment, no network, no service calls, nobody's ever come to visit. On the sheet, they draw what a light bulb draws." He tilted the screen at me. It was a line, a green one, running along the top of a graph with no dips in it at all. "That's that row. That's full load. It's been full load for six years. It isn't connected to anything. I've traced it. I went up in the ceiling. All I can find are the power feeds, going in."

I'm a reconciler. There's a feeling you get when you lay a sheet against a sheet and they don't agree, a little drop, like missing a stair. I had never had it so hard.

"What does it do?"

"Give me your hand," Teo said. He took it, quite impersonally, and laid it flat on the grey door, and laid his own beside it, and shut his eyes, with his dead ear towards the metal. "I do this. It's how I found it. You feel that? Under the fans?"

Everything in that building hummed. This was lower. It came up through the heel of my hand and into the wrist and I knew it, I knew it before I had any words for it. A big man gone thin, in a café, looking at his tea. *You could feel it through the seat.*

"What time is it?" I said.

He opened his eyes, and looked at his watch, and I saw his face go still.

"It's four minutes past," he said.

The hour had gone. She'd be out on the floor already. He had his mouth open to say something, and the tablet in his hand gave a small, polite chirp, and we both looked down.

The graph had gone. In its place, filling the screen, there was a grid.

Twelve by twelve. I didn't need to count; I counted. Black squares and white, in no order that I could see, and they weren't quite still. They were changing, a few at a time, here, and here, the way a departures board changes, like someone filling in a form. I had time to think that there was a row along the top that had almost been completed. I had time to think, *That's a ledger*. I'd spent eleven years looking at them, and I've never been so sure of anything.

Down the aisle behind us, a door beeped.

"No, no," Teo said, without any sound at all. He had his thumb on the screen, and the grid went, and the ticket box came up, and he was already pushing me. There was nowhere to go but back along the row and round the end of the cage, into the slot between the grey cabinets and the wall.

It was two feet wide. It was the hot side. They'd been blowing their breath into it for six years, and it closed over my head like a wet coat. I went in sideways and stood with my spine against the back of the last cabinet. There wasn't anywhere else to stand. It shook, very slightly, all the way up my back.

I heard her before I saw anything: rubber soles, and a set of keys. A torch beam came along the floor at the end of my slot, and it stopped, and it lay there on the tiles, about nine inches from my

left boot.

"You talking to yourself again, Teo?"

"Always, Sheila." He'd raised his voice. It sounded quite normal. It was the bravest thing I've ever heard. "Thought you'd been and gone."

"I'm late. My knee. What've you got?"

"Same old. Picture on the feed."

"Oh, that." The beam moved an inch, and it came back. She had stopped to look at something, and I couldn't think what. The sweat was running into my eyes and I didn't dare lift a hand. My heart had got into step with the thing behind me, or the thing behind me had got into step with my heart, and I'd have given a great deal not to have thought of that. "You want to get that looked at. And somebody's left the back fire door on the latch. I've told you about that."

"That's me. Smoke break."

A pause. I counted it. I got to seven.

"You'll catch your death," said Sheila, and the keys moved off.

Neither of us moved for a long time after the door beeped. When I came out of the slot, my shirt had stuck to me and my legs didn't feel like anything in particular. Teo was sitting on an upturned crate with his head on one side, and his hands were shaking, and he was writing up the ticket.

No fault found.

"She didn't see," he said. "We're fine. I've got the logs till the end of the month, I can clear the door. Nobody looks." He got up, and walked me to the end of the aisle, fast, keeping us out from under the domes, pointing up with one finger as we passed each. There was another, a small one, at the corner of the row by the grey cage, and he didn't bother to steer me round that. He shook his head at it. "That's dead. That's been dead for six years, there's a ticket on it. I closed it myself."

I looked up as I went under.

I've told you I read the small print on things. In the black glass of the dome, very small, very steady, like the last star on a cloudy night, there was a red light.

I didn't say anything. He'd just stood in front of a torch for me, he had a mortgage and one good ear, and I had nothing to give him but that. I looked at it for one pace, then two. Then I looked at my boots, and went out over the sill into the morning.

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WEDNESDAY 10 JUNE

THERE'S A BUS at 6:40 from the ring road, when the night shifts change. I walked the mile to the stop along the verge, with the hi-vis in a carrier bag, and the light coming up pink over the retail park, and the first lark of the day going off somewhere above the dual carriageway, which I thought was brave of it. I hadn't been so happy since I was a child. I'd found something. I'd laid my hand on it. I was still alive, and nobody knew.

There was a man in the shelter.

He had a small brown terrier on a short lead, sitting by his foot, and a newspaper folded under one arm. He moved along the bench to make room for me, though there was plenty of room, and I said thanks. It was the sort of thing you say. I sat down. The dog didn't look at me.

"Lovely morning," he said.

"Yes."

"Mrs Okafor-Reyes? Lovely. Won't keep you."

The lark went on. Very far off, a lorry changed gear. I'd like to say I felt something in that moment, some cold thing, but I didn't, not yet. I felt the seat. I looked at the road, at the place where the bus would come from, and my mind did what it does, and it began quietly to reconcile.

"Ms," I said.

"I do beg your pardon." He seemed really sorry. He had a nice, plain voice, nothing you could have placed. "Six hours and fifty

minutes," he said. "That Tuesday, the twenty-first. Bottom three shelves. You didn't stop for lunch. You want to look after yourself; you don't eat. Your friend's quite right about that." He scratched the dog behind its ear, and it took no notice. "The tea's stewed at that café, I always think, but they're nice people. You found it all right, with the steering wheel? It's hard to write on. I've tried."

A coat. A newspaper. Please and thank you.

I turned my head then. I want you to know that I looked at him. I looked him full in the face in good daylight from two feet away, and I looked for a long time, for I was never going to be caught like that again. Then I looked past him, because there was something white beyond the end of the shelter, on the verge, where there's no reason to park anything. A small van, with a bird on the side, all wings.

I knew the first four characters of its number plate, because I had them in my notebook, in the same pen I'd used on the back of my hand.

He'd parked it so that I could read them.

"You've met Graham," the man said, following my eye with mild interest. "Nice chap. He ought to go ahead with that yellow, you know. I've told him. It's only a door." He looked at his watch, and he looked up the road, and there, small and square in the pink light, were the headlights of the bus. "Here's yours. On time, too. They're very good, on this route."

He stood up, because I had. He was the sort of man who would. He didn't come any nearer. He hadn't said a thing you could have written down and shown to a policeman. He hadn't asked me where I'd been all night. He had not mentioned the ring road, or the fans, or a man with one good ear, and I stood with my carrier bag in my hand, and I understood that he had taken some care not to, and I couldn't tell whether that was because he didn't know or because he did.

The doors opened. I got on. I tapped my card on the reader and it beeped, and I walked down the bus to the back on legs that be-

longed to someone else. I sat down and got out my notebook, because writing things down is the one thing I've got. *Height. Build. Colour. Distinguishing marks.* I pressed so hard the pen went through.

Nobody else had got on.

When we pulled away I looked back through the rear window. He hadn't moved. He stood at the edge of the kerb in the early light with the lead in one hand, and as the bus drew off he lifted two fingers, the small wave you give on a country lane.

It wasn't for anybody else. There was nobody else there.

And at the end of the lead, for the first time, the dog was looking up.